

GetThe Network

Domain Marketplace Viability Report

Comprehensive Analysis of Market Opportunity,
Competitive Landscape, Legal Requirements & Go-to-Market Strategy
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Prepared for Moby | Solo Founder Assessment

Executive Summary

This report assesses the viability of launching the GetThe Network, a family of TLD-specific domain marketplaces (getthe.com, getthe.org, and potentially getthe.io, getthe.ai) as a solo-founder operation leveraging AI agents for automation.

Bottom Line: This is a viable niche business with modest revenue potential, but faces significant headwinds from entrenched competition, the classic chicken-and-egg marketplace problem, and legal complexity around escrow. The strongest path is a differentiated, AI-native platform targeting underserved mid-tier sellers (\$500–\$10K domains) with lower fees, faster transactions, and a modern UX — areas where incumbents are weakest. Expect 12–18 months to reach meaningful traction and plan on \$20K–50K in year-one investment (mostly marketing and legal).

1. Market Overview

The domain name industry is healthy and growing. The global market was valued at approximately \$10 billion in 2025–2026, with the aftermarket (buying/selling previously registered domains) generating over \$244 million in tracked sales volume through NameBio alone in 2025 — up 31.9% from 2024. The true aftermarket is far larger since NameBio captures only an estimated 5–10% of retail transactions.

Key Market Data Points

Metric	Value
Global domain market size (2026)	~\$10.5 billion
Domain aftermarket tracked sales (2025)	\$244M+ via NameBio (5–10% of total)
Aftermarket YoY growth	+31.9% in dollar volume (2025 vs 2024)
Median sale price at Sedo	\$549
.com share of aftermarket sales	72% of dollar volume
Total domain escrow market	~\$50 million annually
Domain parking industry	~\$1.2 billion annually
Global registered domains	362+ million (Q1 2024)
Industry growth rate (CAGR)	4.5–6.2% through 2033

The market is unquestionably active. Domains remain essential for businesses — .com dominates, but .ai is booming (quadrupled in size over 3 years), and new gTLDs grew 16% in 2024. The shift toward AI-powered business creation is actually increasing domain demand, not decreasing it.

2. Do People Still Care About Domains?

Yes, emphatically. While social media handles and app stores have created alternatives for online presence, domains remain the foundational digital identity layer for businesses. Key evidence:

- GoDaddy returned to Super Bowl advertising in 2025, now positioning domains as the entry point for AI-generated business infrastructure
- .com still accounts for 72% of aftermarket dollar volume; .ai aftermarket sales are booming
- OpenAI paid \$15.5 million for chat.com in 2024 — the biggest domain sale of the year
- Mid-range transactions are growing steadily, driven by startups and SMEs, indicating broad-based demand
- The ICANN new gTLD application window in 2026 signals continued institutional investment in the namespace

The narrative that "domains are dead" is wrong. What is true is that the market is maturing, with more sophisticated buyers who expect better tools and lower friction.

2. Competitive Landscape

The domain aftermarket is dominated by a handful of established players. Understanding their strengths and, critically, their weaknesses is essential for finding your wedge.

Major Competitors

Platform	Strengths	Weaknesses	Commission	Listings
Sedo	Largest int'l reach, 19M+ listings, brokerage, parking	Outdated UI, slow support, high fees, false bids, EU compliance delays	10–20%	19M+
Afternic	GoDaddy network distribution to 100+ registrars	20% commission, limited non-.com support, less modern	15–25%	Large
GoDaddy Auctions	Highest volume, trusted brand, quick sales	High fees, less premium focus	15–25%	Millions
Flippa	Startup focus, websites + domains	\$29–\$99 listing fees, overpriced listings	10% + listing	Medium
Atom.com	Curated brandable domains with logos	30–40% commission, small inventory	30–40%	Curated
NamePros	Community-driven, peer-to-peer, 0% commission	No escrow built-in, forum-based UX	0%	Forum

Note: Dan.com (formerly a popular low-commission platform at 0% seller fees) was shut down in June 2025 and merged into Afternic. This removed a key competitor and left a gap in the market for a modern, low-fee platform.

3. Incumbent Pain Points — Your Opportunity

Analysis of hundreds of reviews and forum discussions reveals consistent frustrations with existing platforms. These represent your primary differentiation opportunities:

Common Complaints

- Outdated, clunky interfaces — Sedo's UI hasn't meaningfully changed in over a decade. Multiple reviewers describe it as "dusty" and "medieval"
- High commissions — 10–25% is standard, with some platforms charging 30–40%. Sellers feel nickel-and-dimed
- Slow transaction processing — transfers that should take minutes can take weeks. Buyers and sellers report waiting with no communication
- Poor customer support — slow email responses, no real-time chat, generic answers. Support quality reportedly scales with transaction size
- Fake/unverified bids — no buyer verification means sellers waste time on fraudulent offers. Anyone can create an account and bid with no deposit
- Opaque processes — sellers can't see buyer info, pricing changes feel arbitrary, brokerage results are unpredictable
- Rigid policies — sellers can't cancel listings easily, forced to honor sales they didn't intend
- Weak security — complaints about lack of 2FA, account hacking, unauthorized listings

What GetThe Could Do Differently

- 5–8% commission (half the industry average), transparent fee structure
- Modern, clean, mobile-first UI built with current web technologies
- AI-powered instant domain appraisals visible to both buyer and seller
- Verified buyer accounts with deposit requirements before bidding/offering
- Real-time transaction tracking with automated status updates
- Crypto escrow option for faster, cheaper international transactions
- AI chatbot for instant customer support, escalating to human only when needed
- Transparent marketplace analytics — show recent comparable sales, traffic data, keyword trends

4. Recommended Business Model & Strategy

Phase 1: Launch (Months 1–6)

Start with a listing marketplace focused on mid-tier domains (\$500–\$10,000). This is the sweet spot where Sedo reports the most growth and where sellers are most underserved. Premium domains (\$50K+) require brokerage relationships you don't have yet, and budget domains (<\$500) have thin margins.

- Launch getthe.com first (72% of aftermarket is .com)
- Offer free basic listings, charge 5–8% commission on sales only
- Integrate with Escrow.com for payment handling (avoids money transmitter licensing)
- Add domain parking via a partnership with a parking provider (low-effort revenue stream)
- Build AI-powered domain appraisal tool as a lead magnet / free public tool

Phase 2: Expansion (Months 6–12)

- Launch getthe.org for .org domains (niche focus = marketing angle)
- Add Make Offer and simple auction functionality
- Introduce crypto escrow option (USDC on Ethereum via smart contract or partner service like Uniscrow)
- Build SedoMLS-style integration with registrar partners for distribution

Phase 3: Scale (Months 12–24)

- Acquire getthe.ai and getthe.io to capture hot TLD markets
- Add brokerage services (AI-assisted outreach to potential buyers)
- Expand to expired domain auctions
- Consider white-label marketplace for registrars

The TLD-Specific Sites Question

Running separate sites per TLD is a mixed bag. Pros: Strong SEO positioning (getthe.com ranks for ".com domains for sale"), clear brand identity per TLD, focused marketing. Cons: Splits traffic and inventory, more domains to maintain, buyers often search across TLDs.

Recommendation: Build one codebase with a shared backend and database. Use TLD-specific frontends as marketing entry points, but allow cross-TLD browsing. Think of it like Zillow having separate entry pages for different cities but one unified search. The "GetThe Network" brand ties them together.

5. Leveraging AI

This is your strongest differentiator. None of the incumbents are AI-native. Here's where AI agents can transform the business:

Core AI Applications

- Domain Appraisal Engine — Train on NameBio sales data, keyword trends, SEO metrics, and brandability scores. Offer free instant appraisals to attract sellers. This alone can be a powerful lead magnet
- AI-Powered Buyer Matching — When a domain is listed, automatically identify potential buyers (companies in relevant industries, recent funding rounds in related sectors) and generate personalized outreach
- Smart Pricing Suggestions — Recommend listing prices based on comparable sales, keyword demand trends, and time-of-year seasonality
- Automated Negotiation Agent — AI chatbot that handles initial buyer-seller negotiation, counter-offers, and FAQ within parameters set by the seller
- Fraud Detection — Flag suspicious bids, verify buyer intent through behavioral analysis, and require deposits for high-value offers
- Content Generation — Auto-generate listing descriptions, SEO-optimized landing pages for parked domains, and marketing copy
- Customer Support Bot — Handle 90%+ of support queries (transaction status, transfer instructions, pricing questions) without human intervention
- Market Intelligence Dashboard — Real-time analytics on TLD trends, keyword demand, and pricing movements

Running the platform with AI agents + you as a solo founder is realistic for the marketplace itself. The AI handles listing management, appraisals, buyer outreach, support, and routine operations. You focus on strategy, partnerships, dispute resolution, and growth.

6. Crypto Escrow

Crypto escrow for domain transactions is technically feasible and could be a meaningful differentiator, particularly for international transactions where traditional payment methods are slow or expensive.

Implementation Options

- Partner approach (recommended to start): Integrate with an existing crypto escrow service like Uniscrow or Cryptoexchange.com. They handle compliance, smart contracts, and dispute resolution. You earn referral fees or pass through at lower cost than traditional escrow
- Custom smart contract (Phase 2+): Build an Ethereum-based escrow smart contract using USDC (stablecoin) to avoid volatility risk. Buyer deposits USDC, domain transfers verified via registrar API, smart contract releases funds automatically
- Hybrid model: Offer both traditional (via Escrow.com) and crypto escrow, letting buyers choose

Crypto Escrow Pros & Cons

- Pros: Lower fees (potentially 1–2% vs 3–5% traditional), instant international settlement, 24/7 availability, no chargebacks, appeals to crypto-savvy domain investors
- Cons: Limits buyer pool to crypto holders, regulatory uncertainty, smart contract bugs can be catastrophic, still need dispute resolution mechanism, most domain buyers are not yet crypto-native

Key insight: Don't build custom escrow from day one. Use Escrow.com for fiat transactions (they're already licensed in 49 states) and add crypto escrow as an option via a partner service. Building your own escrow is a legal and regulatory minefield (see Legal section).

7. Legal Issues & Complexities

This is the most underestimated area. Running a domain marketplace touches several regulatory domains:

Escrow & Money Transmission

If you handle funds between buyer and seller, you may be classified as a money transmitter under federal (FinCEN) and state laws. Key points:

- Traditional escrow services that act as independent arbiters of transaction completion are generally NOT classified as money transmitters per FinCEN rulings. But this is fact-specific
- Escrow.com holds licenses in 49+ states as a money services business. Getting similar licensing yourself would cost \$500K+ and take 12–18 months
- Using a licensed escrow partner (Escrow.com) avoids this entirely. They handle compliance, you handle the marketplace
- Adding crypto escrow introduces additional complexity: potential SEC implications, state-by-state crypto money transmitter rules, AML/KYC requirements

Other Legal Considerations

- UDRP (Uniform Domain-Name Dispute Resolution Policy) — You'll need a clear policy for handling trademark disputes on listed domains. ICANN's UDRP framework provides guidance but you should have legal counsel draft your marketplace policies
- Terms of Service — Must clearly define binding agreement terms. Sedo faces lawsuits over sellers refusing to complete accepted offers. Your TOS needs to be bulletproof
- Privacy (GDPR/CCPA) — Domain WHOIS data is personally identifiable. You'll need privacy policies compliant with EU GDPR and California CCPA at minimum
- Consumer Protection — State consumer protection laws apply to marketplace transactions. Refund policies, dispute resolution procedures, and disclosure requirements vary by state
- Business Formation — LLC recommended, with consideration for Delaware incorporation for liability protection
- Insurance — E&O (Errors & Omissions) and cyber liability insurance advisable

Estimated legal costs: \$5,000–\$15,000 for initial TOS, privacy policy, and marketplace agreement drafting. Additional \$2,000–5,000/year for ongoing legal review. Budget \$3,000–5,000 for trademark registration of "GetThe" across relevant classes.

8. Marketing & Customer Acquisition

This is where most marketplace startups fail. You face the classic chicken-and-egg problem: sellers won't list without buyers, buyers won't come without inventory.

Bootstrapping Strategy

Seed inventory yourself. Buy 50–100 quality domains across .com and .org in the \$50–500 range. List them on your platform to create initial inventory. This investment (\$5,000–15,000) gives you real listings to show potential sellers and attracts organic search traffic.

Marketing Channels & Budget

Channel	Approach	Monthly Cost	Priority
SEO / Content	Blog, domain appraisal tool, guides. Target long-tail keywords	\$0–500 (your time)	Critical
NamePros / Forums	Establish presence on domainer forums, sponsor threads, offer free listings	\$200–500	Critical
Google Ads	Target "sell domain name" and "domain appraisal" keywords	\$1,000–2,500	High
Social / Twitter/X	Domain sales highlights, market data, appraisal tool promotion	\$0–200	Medium
Direct Outreach	AI-generated personalized emails to domain holders with expiring/parked domains	\$100–300 (tooling)	High
Partnerships	Referral deals with registrars, hosting companies, web agencies	\$0 (rev share)	Medium

Total recommended Year 1 marketing budget: \$15,000–\$30,000. Heavier spend in months 1–6 to build initial inventory and awareness, tapering as organic traffic grows. The AI domain appraisal tool is your single best lead magnet — invest heavily in making it excellent.

Getting Sellers to List

The hardest part. Strategies that work:

- Lower fees than every competitor (5–8% vs 10–25%). Lead with this in all messaging
- Free AI appraisals — sellers come for the appraisal, stay to list
- One-click import from other platforms — build a tool that lets sellers import their Sedo/ Afternic portfolio to your platform in minutes
- Guaranteed listing promotion — every domain gets a landing page with SEO optimization, not just premium listings

- Quick payment — commit to 24-hour payout after transfer confirmation (vs days/weeks at Sedo)
- No lock-in — let sellers list simultaneously on other platforms with no penalty

9. Time Investment

Realistic assessment for a solo technical founder using AI coding assistants:

Phase	Duration	Hours/Week
Platform build (MVP)	2–3 months	25–40 hrs/wk
Legal setup (LLC, TOS, policies)	1–2 months (parallel)	5–10 hrs/wk
Initial inventory seeding	1 month (parallel)	10 hrs/wk
Marketing & seller outreach	Ongoing from month 2	10–15 hrs/wk
Platform operations (steady state)	Ongoing from month 3	10–20 hrs/wk

Total to launch: ~300–500 hours over 3 months. Steady-state operations: 15–25 hours/week if heavily automated. This is manageable as a side project alongside your role at Abnormal Security, but will require focused weekend/evening blocks during the build phase. The AI agents handle listing management, support, and outreach; you handle strategy, partnerships, disputes, and platform improvements.

10. Staffing Requirements

For a solo founder with AI agents:

- Months 1–12: Just you. AI handles support, listing management, appraisals, and outreach. You handle everything else
- At ~\$10K/month revenue: Consider a part-time VA (\$500–1,000/month) for dispute resolution and seller onboarding support
- At ~\$25K/month revenue: Consider a part-time marketing contractor (\$1,500–3,000/month) for content and partnerships
- At ~\$50K/month revenue: First full-time hire (operations/customer success)

You do NOT need human brokers at launch. AI can handle initial negotiations and appraisals. Human brokers become valuable only for \$25K+ transactions where personal relationships matter.

11. Revenue Projections

Conservative projections assuming very low market penetration:

Scenario: 0.1% of Addressable Aftermarket

The domain aftermarket generates an estimated \$500M–\$1B+ annually in total retail transactions (NameBio captures \$244M at 5–10% coverage). At 0.1% market share:

Metric	Year 1	Year 2	Year 3
Transactions/month	5–15	20–50	50–150
Avg transaction value	\$800	\$1,200	\$1,500
GMV/month	\$4K–\$12K	\$24K–\$60K	\$75K–\$225K
Commission revenue (7%)	\$280–\$840/mo	\$1.7K–\$4.2K/mo	\$5.3K–\$15.8K/mo
Parking/other revenue	\$100–\$500/mo	\$500–\$2K/mo	\$2K–\$5K/mo
Total annual revenue	\$5K–\$16K	\$26K–\$74K	\$88K–\$250K

Reality check: Year 1 will likely not cover costs. This is normal for marketplaces. Break-even (covering ~\$2,000–3,000/month in hosting, marketing, and domain renewals) is realistic in Year 2. Profitability as a meaningful income source is a Year 3 target. This works best as a side business that grows into a primary one.

12. Primary Barriers & Risks

Critical Risks

- Chicken-and-egg problem — The #1 killer of marketplace startups. Without sellers you have no inventory; without inventory you attract no buyers. Mitigation: seed your own inventory, offer free/ultra-low-fee listings, build the appraisal tool as a traffic driver
- Trust deficit — Domain transactions involve real money and unknown parties. New platforms face skepticism. Mitigation: use Escrow.com for payments (instant credibility), publish transaction data transparently, get early testimonials
- Incumbent network effects — Sedo has 2M+ users and 19M listings. GoDaddy has massive distribution. You can't compete on scale. Mitigation: compete on experience, fees, and AI features. Target underserved segments (mid-tier, non-.com TLDs)
- Legal/regulatory complexity — Escrow, money transmission, and dispute resolution require careful legal navigation. Mitigation: partner with licensed escrow providers, get legal counsel early
- Revenue timeline — Expect 12–18 months before meaningful revenue. Need to sustain investment through this period

Moderate Risks

- Domain market cyclical — Aftermarket activity fluctuates with tech investment cycles. A downturn could slow growth

- Platform abuse — Scammers, domain squatters listing trademarked names, fake bidding
- Technical complexity — Registrar API integrations, automated domain transfers, escrow system reliability
- AI accuracy — Domain appraisals are inherently subjective. Bad AI valuations erode trust quickly

13. Customer Acquisition Strategy

Focus on the supply side first (sellers), since buyers will come for desirable inventory.

Seller Acquisition Playbook

- Build the best free domain appraisal tool on the internet. Make it AI-powered, instant, and shareable. This is your top-of-funnel engine
- Scrape WHOIS and expiring domain databases to identify owners of quality domains. Use AI to generate personalized outreach emails offering free premium listings
- Post regularly on NamePros, DNForum, and other domainer communities. Become a known, helpful presence before pitching your platform
- Offer a "migration special" — 0% commission on first sale for sellers who import listings from Sedo/Afternic
- Create a referral program — give sellers 1% commission reduction for every new seller they refer
- Partner with smaller registrars who want marketplace features they can't build themselves (white-label opportunity)

Buyer Acquisition

- SEO is king — every listed domain should have its own landing page optimized for "buy [domainname]" searches
- Google Ads for "buy domain" and TLD-specific keywords
- AI-powered buyer prospecting: identify companies that might want specific listed domains based on their industry, recent funding, or brand strategy

14. Final Assessment & Recommendation

Factor	Assessment
Market viability	Strong — growing market, clear demand
Competition	High — but incumbents are stale
Differentiation opportunity	Strong — AI-native + low fees + modern UX
Solo founder feasibility	Feasible with AI agents, manageable as side project
Revenue timeline	Slow — 12–18 months to break even
Year 1 investment needed	\$20K–\$50K (domains, legal, marketing, hosting)

Year 3 revenue potential (0.1% share)	\$88K–\$250K annually
Legal complexity	Moderate — use partners to avoid licensing
Overall recommendation	PROCEED WITH CAUTION — viable niche business, start lean

The GetThe Network is a viable business concept with real differentiation potential. The domain aftermarket is growing, incumbents are vulnerable on UX and fees, and AI gives you a genuine technical moat as a solo founder. The key risks are the marketplace cold-start problem and the slow revenue ramp.

The best approach is to treat this as a funded side project for the first 12 months. Build the MVP and appraisal tool with AI agents over 2–3 months, seed initial inventory with \$5–10K in domain purchases, budget \$15–30K for year-one marketing and legal, and validate demand before committing full-time. If you can reach 20+ transactions/month by month 12, the economics work and it's worth scaling.

The TLD-specific branding (GetThe.com, GetThe.org, GetThe.ai) is a clever marketing hook that creates natural SEO advantages and memorable positioning. Combined with AI-powered appraisals, low fees, crypto escrow options, and a modern UI, you have a credible pitch to both sellers and buyers in an industry ripe for disruption.